

Sunk Cost

A 1–4 player co-op salvage horror game. Around the year 2300, on an ocean world, a pirate crew lowers you to the seafloor to work off a debt you will never clear. You walk in the dark, drag treasure back to a glass elevator, and every time it rises it screams your position across the ocean.

CREW	CAPACITY	ENGINE	RELEASE	PRICE
3 devs	~60 h / week	Unity / C#	Early Access	\$10–15

The loop

Two surface locations, one cycle of three dives between them. This replaces the day-by-day structure in the original concept document.

HQ Between cycles	The pirates' base Pay the quota, buy equipment, and save . This is the only save point, so a cycle is a commitment you can't put down halfway. Miss the quota here and everyone walks the plank — the run is over.
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BOAT Between dives	The salvage vessel One big screen listing every site, which doubles as the TV surfaced players watch divers on. A storage room holding everything you've hauled up, as physical objects. A readout of what you have against what you owe. No shop.
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DIVE × 3 per cycle	Descend together Vote a site, ride down as a crew in the glass elevator. One tank of air each, no refills. Walk, find salvage, carry it back, send it up. The elevator is loud every time it moves.
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UP

Whenever

Leave when you decide

Anyone can ride up at any time. Once you're up, you can't go back down — and the noise of your escape tells the ocean where everyone else still is.

The elevator

It is a real elevator. It carries **any number of people and any amount of cargo together** — one diver or the whole crew, with or without treasure. Anything can also be sent up **with no passenger at all**: load treasure, or a body, pull the lever, and keep diving. Whatever goes up is safe forever.

There is only one of it. That is the entire constraint. When it goes up it is gone until it comes back — roughly 30 seconds each way — and anyone who needs it during that window simply waits.

WHY IT WORKS

Your exit is not a thing you have, it is a thing that can be somewhere else. Sending treasure up means nobody can leave for a minute. One person bailing early strands everyone else, and they watch it happen through the glass.

So **depositing is dangerous twice over**: the winch screams your position across the ocean, *and* your only way out is gone. The original concept called depositing "safety and danger at the same time" — with one shared elevator that is now true in two separate ways at once.

Setting

ELEMENT	DECISION
Era	Roughly 2300. Futuristic pirates — raiders and scavengers, not a corporation.
Place	An ocean world, not Earth.
What's down there	A failed human colony built over much older alien ruins. Shallow sites are colony housing and wrecked ships; deeper sites get progressively less human until nothing makes sense. Never explained.
Loot	Mixed — recognisable human junk for comedy and volume, alien artifacts for the high-value scares.
Tone	Played completely straight. The game is never funny on purpose; every laugh comes from physics, panic and your friends.
Art direction	Stylised and chunky, in the R.E.P.O. / PEAK direction. Low-poly geometry, flat shading, bold silhouettes. Not photorealistic.

ELEMENT	DECISION
Audio	Ambient drones underwater, real music on the ship.
Ship name	Black Tide Salvage — replaces "The Black Gull". Reads as a company that owns people.

The dive

SYSTEM	DECISION
Camera	First person with a visible body.
Movement	Walking only, no swimming. The in-world reason is still open.
Suits	Identical for everyone, cosmetic skins purchasable. Each player has a distinct lamp colour — that's how you identify a shape in the dark.
Air	One tank per diver, no refills anywhere. 12–15 minutes base. Larger tanks purchasable but physically heavier; portable spare bottles are carried items you activate.
Air drain	Faster when sprinting, carrying weight, or damaged. Greed literally costs you air.
Damage	Attacks can open a leak. Patch it with an item or a teammate. No regeneration — healing is items only.
Lethality	Depends on the monster, your current health, and your oxygen level. Low air makes you fragile, so a bad dive accelerates.
Carrying	4 inventory slots plus one hand. Large objects are hands-only. Weight slows you and burns air.
Sharing	Everything can be dropped, thrown and picked up. No trade menu.
Friendly fire	None.
Safe rooms	None on the seafloor. Everything you need, you carry.

Death, bodies and equipment

The rule set that makes people play carefully, and the reason dragging a corpse is a decision rather than a gesture.

Dying costs you everything you bought. Every purchased upgrade — tanks, lights, tools, radio — is gone. Not damaged, not dropped on the floor: gone. You come back for the next dive with nothing but the base kit.

Unless your body comes up. If the crew gets your corpse to the surface, you keep all of it. A body is cargo worth recovering, and recovering it is a favour with a number attached.

What this creates. The body competes with the treasure for your **hands** and your **air** — not for space in the elevator, which has plenty. Carrying a friend back means carrying less gold and moving slowly while you do it, and you have to say out loud which one you chose. That's the game's whole question, pointed at a person instead of an object.

Bodies are heavy. Two hands, badly slowed, nothing else carried. Dragging someone is a commitment you feel.

Rules that must hold

- **The base kit is always free and always full.** Death takes your purchases, never your ability to dive again. Without this you get a death spiral: whoever died is now the poorest, so they die more, so they stay poorest.
- **Banked loot is unaffected.** Anything already sent up stays up. Death costs equipment, never the crew's earnings.
- **A disconnected player's body behaves exactly like a dead one** — stays where it fell, carries their gear, recoverable.
- **A body can be sent up alone.** Load it in, pull the lever, keep diving. Saving a friend's gear costs you the carry and the elevator's absence, not your own exit.

WATCH THIS ONE IN PLAYTEST

Losing **100%** of purchases may be too harsh late in a run, when gear is expensive and a single bad dive erases hours. Consider keeping one item, or losing a percentage. Start harsh — it is far easier to soften a rule after a playtest than to tighten one people have got used to.

Interface

ELEMENT	DECISION
Visor	Shows the basics as an AR overlay. Loot values appear floating over objects.
Handheld device	Detailed readouts, scans, compass. Raising it narrows your view and occupies a hand — checking your air means not watching the dark.
Navigation	A compass in the suit. No map.
Leak feedback	Must be unmissable: a hiss in the helmet, bubbles past the visor, a visible jump in drain rate. Two interacting resources only work if players can see them interact.

Sites and conditions

SYSTEM	DECISION
Count	Four at launch.

SYSTEM	DECISION
Choosing	Vote a site before each of the three dives. A crew that's behind can gamble on somewhere worse.
Construction	Hand-built rooms assembled procedurally.
Size	Bounded content that feels unbounded. No walls or warnings — the built area simply stops containing anything, so walking further is pointless rather than forbidden. Oxygen is the real limit.
Conditions	Zero to two rolled per dive. Mostly bad (blackout, infestation, silt storm), occasionally good (calm, rich vein).
Condition info	Not shown beforehand. A harder dive silently rolls item values toward the top of their range.
Loot values	Randomised within a fixed range each run, and always visible through the visor.
Breakage	Nothing breaks, for now.
Monsters	Five or six at launch. Behaviour varies by creature — some hunt until the dive ends, some lose interest once they can't reach you.

ONE FIX NEEDED

If conditions are never shown, most players will never notice the system exists — a hard dive just feels hard and the bonus is invisible. Reveal them on the results screen instead: **BLACKOUT · +30%** beside the totals. Players learn it exists after the fact and start hoping for it.

Crew, death and spectating

SYSTEM	DECISION
Crew size	Up to 4. Solo uses the same rules and is simply harder.
Quota scaling	Partial — more players raises the target, but less than it raises your earning power.
Lobbies	Friends and invite codes at launch. Public matchmaking later if players ask.
Dead players	Watch any diver, click to switch. Talk only to other dead players.
Surfaced players	One shared TV on the boat — everyone up top watches the same diver and has to agree who. Talk only to each other.
Talking to divers	Requires a purchasable surface radio.
Disconnects	The body stays where it fell and the loot is recoverable. Rejoin at HQ between cycles, not mid-dive.

SYSTEM	DECISION
Bodies	Draggable, heavy, and worth recovering — see <i>Death, bodies and equipment</i> .

Economy and progression

SYSTEM	DECISION
Funds	Shared crew pot. One shop, at HQ only.
Storage	The boat's storage room is display only — a pile of physical objects growing across three dives. It sells at HQ.
Banked loot	Anything sent up is safe permanently, even on a total wipe.
Quota curve	Gentle for the first few cycles, then accelerating past what a careful crew can earn. Most runs should end between cycle 6 and 12.
Early return	You can go back to HQ before all three dives. The cycle ends and the quota is judged immediately.
Run length	Endless. There is no ending — the run recap screen is the ending, every time.
Failure	Miss the quota, walk the plank, run over.
Between runs	Cosmetics only, unlocked through achievements. No permanent power, so the early game stays frightening forever.
Difficulty	One difficulty for everyone. The site vote is how you choose your risk.
Teaching	No tutorial. The starter site is survivable enough that players learn noise matters by getting away with it once.

CONSEQUENCE WORTH PLANNING FOR

Endless, no difficulty settings, no ending — so the **quota curve is the entire difficulty design**. One escalating number carries all of the game's pacing, and it will need more tuning passes than anything else you build. Design the achievement list and the cosmetic list as the same list.

Still open

QUESTION	WHERE IT STANDS
Why you can't swim	OPEN Best option: thrusters exist, but they're loud, burn air and draw creatures — so swimming is an emergency you regret. Build walking-only for now; the fiction can be attached any time before launch.

QUESTION

WHERE IT STANDS

Which 5–6 monsters	OPEN	Build the Bell Eater first — it's drawn to the elevator, so it tests the core loop directly.
Elevator round trip	OPEN	30 seconds provisionally. The most important tuning number in the game — it decides how badly a stranded diver suffers. Expect to change it after the first playtest.
Equipment loss on death	OPEN	Currently 100% of purchases. May be too harsh late in a run. Start harsh and soften after playtesting.
Personal debt	OPEN	A visible per-player debt alongside the crew quota is what makes the title mechanically true rather than thematic.
Title	OPEN	"Sunk Cost" vs "Black Tide". Search Steam and a trademark register before anyone gets attached to either.
Loot breakage	OPEN	Deferred. Fragile items only, if ever.
Revenue split	AGREED	Equal three ways. Write it down, and include what happens if someone stops contributing halfway.

Technical spine

Three people doing networked 3D physics horror is one of the harder things in indie development. It's been done — with these specific shortcuts.

Networked physics: don't chase determinism

Use **ownership transfer**. Whoever grabs an object simulates it locally and broadcasts its transform. Jank is acceptable in this genre; it's where the clips come from. Chasing perfect sync is the most common way a project like this dies.

The noise system is the spine — build it week one

Every loud action fires one event: `NoiseEvent(position, loudness, type)`. The elevator, footsteps, sprinting, a dropped object, a tank swap. Monsters subscribe. Trivial now, agony to retrofit once six creatures have bespoke logic.

Proximity voice is the product, not polish

Radio degradation is a low-pass filter plus static mixed by distance. Two days of work, and the highest value-per-hour feature in the design. It goes in the prototype.

Spectating is cheaper than it looks

You don't stream video. A surfaced player's client is already connected and simulating the level, so you move their camera to the watched diver's head and set their audio listener to that diver's position. Voice inheritance comes free with proximity chat.

Art pipeline

- **Loot objects** → **AI generation**. Static, physics-driven, seen in darkness, and you want a hundred varied ones.
- **Environment kits** → **bought packs**. Stylised sci-fi and modular industrial sets. Consistency beats quality when one lamp lights everything.
- **Players and monsters** → **bought or commissioned**. These need rigs, animation and readable silhouettes, and monsters are what people screenshot.

Check commercial licensing before you ship. Asset store licences are almost always fine; terms for AI-generated 3D vary by service and some restrict commercial use.

Cut from v1

Ship with four sites, five or six monsters, the full loop, and nothing else.

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|-------------------------------|-------------------------|
| • Weather and storms | • Mid-dive reconnection |
| • Map pieces and a final site | • Loot breakage |
| • Minigames | • Trade menus |
| • Crew quarters and bunks | • Difficulty settings |
| • The salvage journal | • Ship decoration |
| • Public server browser | • Boat piloting |

For the prototype, **HQ doesn't exist yet** — a menu stands in for it. The boat is one room. Build the expensive social spaces last.

The descent

Calibrated to roughly 60 person-hours a week. Each phase answers one question before the next is worth starting.

01

Weeks 1–2

Foundations

Can three of us work in one repo without destroying each other?

- Written network contract — RPC naming, ownership rules, how state syncs. Before any gameplay code.
 - Unity project, Git with LFS, Unity `.gitignore`, force text serialization.
 - Two players walking around a grey box over Steam P2P.
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02

Weeks 3–10

The ugly prototype

Is this fun with friends at 11pm? Nothing else matters yet.

- One grey site, the glass elevator, one monster, the noise system.
 - Oxygen, three loot objects with real weight, lamps, the quota.
 - Proximity voice with radio degradation. Not optional.
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03

Months 3–7

Vertical slice

Does the loop survive contact with real content?

- One finished site from modular rooms, three monsters, the condition system.
 - The full three-dive cycle, the boat, HQ, the shop, the plank.
 - Art direction locked and applied end to end on one site.
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04

Months 8–12

Content and visibility

Does anyone outside the three of us want this?

- Remaining sites and monsters, equipment, cosmetics, the run recap.
 - **Steam page live** as soon as you have 30 seconds worth showing.
 - Demo, Next Fest, playtests with small streamers.
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05

Months 13+

Early Access

- Launch into Early Access at \$10–15 with the loop complete and content thin.
- A monster or a site every couple of months — each one is a reason for streamers to cover you again.
- Steam Direct fee, entity and banking sorted well ahead of the date.

THE ONE DEADLINE THAT MATTERS

Do not let phase 02 slip. If you're still building the ugly prototype in month four, something is wrong, and it is almost always networking.

Who owns what

Drawn along module boundaries so three people aren't merge-conflicting all day. The one who has shipped a game takes networking — a wrong call there costs three months, and it's where confident AI-generated garbage is hardest to spot.

DEV A — SHIPPED BEFORE	DEV B	DEV C
- Networking and the contract - Player controller - Grab, carry and drag - Architecture referee	- Monster AI - The noise system - Level assembly tooling - Site construction	- Oxygen, loot, weight, economy - Quota, conditions, shop - Visor, device, run recap - Audio and proximity voice

Rules for three people coding with AI

- **The network contract is written before any code.** Otherwise three AI-assisted developers invent three incompatible conventions in week one. This is the single biggest risk in a project of this size.
- **Small, single-purpose files.** That's what makes AI edits reliable at scale.
- **One person edits a given Unity scene at a time.** Scenes and prefabs merge terribly; enforce it socially.
- **Nobody merges their own architecture changes.** Gameplay tweaks are fine; anything touching the contract gets a second pair of eyes.

The only test that matters

At the end of phase 02, four people play the ugly version. If you hear these unprompted, you have a game and everything after is content:

SUCCESS CRITERIA

"HELP ME CARRY THIS."

"WHAT IS THAT?"

"SEND IT UP!"

"NO NO NO NO NO—"

If you don't hear them, the answer isn't more content. Something in the loop — weight, darkness, noise, or the elevator — isn't doing its job yet, and no amount of sites and monsters will cover for it.

Draft 3 · Reopen any decision with a real argument, not a preference · Next revision once the open questions are settled